Grid-Down Checklist

General safety information, not medical advice or a substitute for training. In an emergency, call 911.

From the free guide at https://jaechung-glitch.github.io/bugout/guides/power-grid-down/, which lists its sources. Updated November 12, 2026.

What to do in the first 24 hours

1. **Find out how big it is.** Turn on a battery or hand-crank radio, or check your utility's outage map while your phone has signal. A whole region dark means plan for days.
2. **Fill water containers now.** Fill bathtubs (for flushing and washing), pots and clean jugs (for drinking) while there's still pressure.
3. **Keep the fridge and freezer closed.** Food stays safe about 4 hours in a closed fridge, 48 hours in a full freezer and 24 hours in a half-full one, according to the USDA.
4. **Switch to flashlights and headlamps.** Candles are a fire risk, and the fire department may be stretched thin.
5. **Unplug electronics.** Power can return in surges. Leave one lamp on so you know when it's back.
6. **Save phone battery.** Low Power Mode, screen dimmed, text instead of calling. Charge from a power bank or a running car outdoors.
7. **Start the medical backup plan.** Anyone who relies on oxygen, a CPAP, dialysis or refrigerated medicine should act now, not when batteries run low. The Red Cross says to evacuate if you depend on powered medical devices and can't run them.
8. **Check on neighbors**, especially older people living alone, and agree how you'll keep in touch.

What stops working when the grid goes

down

Tap water

Why: Utilities pump and treat water with electricity. Low pressure can let contaminants into the pipes, the EPA notes.

What to do: Store water ahead; fill containers early; follow any boil-water notice.

Private wells

Why: The well pump runs on electricity.

What to do: Store water, or have a generator or backup power sized for the pump.

Sewer and toilets

Why: Sewage pumps need power too; when they fail, sewage can back up into homes, the EPA warns.

What to do: Flush less, using a bucket of stored water; keep heavy-duty trash bags for a backup toilet.

Heating

Why: Most gas furnaces need electricity for the blower and ignition.

What to do: Heat one small room; layer up; use a warming center.

Fridge and freezer

Why: No cooling.

What to do: Keep doors shut; use coolers and ice; eat perishables first.

Gas pumps, ATMs and card readers

Why: All need power and a network.

What to do: Keep the car's tank more than half full and some cash in small bills.

Cell phones and internet

Why: Towers have limited backup power, and networks overload.

What to do: Text, don't call; keep power banks charged; own a radio.

Garage doors, electric locks and elevators

Why: They need power to open.

What to do: Learn your garage door's manual release now.

Medical devices and refrigerated medicine

Why: Need power or cold.

What to do: Backup batteries, a plan from your doctor, and a place to go.

Grid-down checklist

Enough to get a household through two weeks without power.

- [ ] Water: 1 gallon per person per day for 2 weeks
  A family of four needs 56 gallons.
- [ ] Two weeks of food that needs no cooking or refrigeration, and a manual can opener
- [ ] A flashlight or headlamp for each person, and extra batteries
- [ ] A battery or hand-crank radio, ideally a NOAA Weather Radio
- [ ] Charged power banks and a car phone charger
- [ ] Battery-powered carbon monoxide alarms
- [ ] A first-aid kit and at least two weeks of everyone's medicines
- [ ] Backup batteries or power for medical devices
- [ ] Cash in small bills
- [ ] Warm bedding and layers, or a plan to stay cool
- [ ] Coolers and ice packs, and fridge and freezer thermometers
- [ ] Unscented bleach and a way to boil water outdoors

- [ ] Heavy-duty trash bags and a bucket for a backup toilet
- [ ] A paper list of phone numbers and a local map
- [ ] A car tank kept more than half full
- [ ] A generator only if you can run it outdoors, at least 20 feet from the house

Tick items off on your iPhone. BugOut, the free offline survival app, lets you make your own checklists and keeps its guides on your phone with no signal.